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accounts, balancing the ledger accounts, carrying ledger account balances to the trial balance, totalling the trial balance columns, etc. Hence, the errors should be located and rectified before preparing the financial statements.

iv) Summarised information of ledger accounts

The summary of ledger accounts is shown in the trial balance. Ledger accounts have to be seen only when details are required in respect of an account.

5.6 Limitations of trial balance

The following are the limitations of trial balance:

a) It is possible to prepare trial balance of an organisation, only if the double entry system is followed.

b) Even if some transactions are omitted, the trial balance will tally.

c) Trial balance may tally even though errors are committed in the books of account.

d) If trial balance is not prepared in a systematic way, the final accounts prepared on the basis of trial balance may not depict the actual state of affairs of the concern.

e) Agreement of trial balance is not a conclusive proof of arithmetical accuracy of entries made in the accounting records. This is because there are certain errors which are not disclosed by trial balance such as complete omission of a transaction, compensating errors and error of principle.

5.7 Methods of preparing trial balance

A trial balance can be prepared in the following methods:

i) **Balance method**
In this method, the balance of every ledger account either debit or credit, as the case may be, is recorded in the trial balance against the respective accounts. The balance method is widely used, as it helps in the preparation of financial statements.

ii) **Total method**
Under this method, the total amounts on the debit side of the ledger accounts and the total amounts on the credit side of the ledger accounts are ascertained and recorded in the trial balance. This method is not commonly used as it cannot help in the preparation of financial statements.

iii) **Total and Balance method**
This method is a combination of both total method and balance method. Under this method, four columns are provided, namely, a) totals of debit side of the ledger accounts, b) totals of the credit side of the ledger accounts c) debit balances of ledger accounts and d) credit balances of the ledger accounts. This method is not in practice.